

CHILDREN OF THE COVENANT

*A History of the Jewish People —
Their Records, Their Myths, and the Legends Made of Both*

By
Divyansh Sharma

From the Ruins of the First Temple to the Myths of the Modern Age

About the Author

Divyansh Sharma is a researcher and writer with a deep interest in the intersection of ancient history, mythology, and the forces that shape the modern world. His work examines how the stories civilizations tell about themselves — their legends, their sacred texts, their supernatural traditions — become the lens through which history is remembered, distorted, and ultimately contested.

Children of the Covenant represents years of research into one of the oldest and most complex subjects in human history: the Jewish people, their three-thousand-year journey from the highland settlements of ancient Canaan to the founding of a modern state, and everything — the mysticism, the folklore, the persecution, the endurance — that happened in between.

Sharma approaches this subject with the conviction that history is best understood when the distinction between documented fact and living myth is kept clear — not because myths are unimportant, but because they are important in a different way than facts. The myths a people tell about themselves reveal what they fear, what they hope for, and what they are determined to survive.

Contents

Foreword: Why This Book Exists

PART I: The Ancient World & Biblical Era

- **Chapter One:** A People Written in Stone
- The God Baal and the Struggle for Monotheism
- The Temple: History and Myth of the House of God

PART II: Kabbalah & Jewish Mysticism

- **Chapter Two:** The Map of God — Kabbalah and the Zohar
- The Zohar and Isaac Luria

PART III: Myths, Folklore & Supernatural Creatures

- **Chapter Three:** The Golem — A Body Without a Soul
- **Chapter Four:** Lilith — The First Rebel
- **Chapter Five:** The Dybbuk — A Soul That Will Not Leave

PART IV: Medieval Era & the Diaspora

- **Chapter Six:** The Long Exile — Medieval Jewry and the World That Feared Them

PART V: Persecution & Survival

- **Chapter Seven:** The Accusation — Blood Libel and the Murder of Innocents

PART VI: Banking Dynasties & Real Political Influence

- **Chapter Eight:** The House of Rothschild — Money, Myth, and Power

PART VII: Zionism & the Birth of Modern Israel

- **Chapter Nine:** Next Year in Jerusalem — The Making of a Modern State

PART VIII: Modern Myths & Conspiracy Theories

- **Chapter Ten:** The Protocols of a Lie — The Most Dangerous Forgery in History

Conclusion: The Covenant Endures

Foreword: Why This Book Exists

There are few peoples on earth who have been written about more, and understood less, than the Jews. For three thousand years they have occupied a peculiar position in the human story — central enough to appear in the founding texts of half the world's religions, yet perpetually cast as outsiders wherever they settled. They have been worshipped as the chosen people of the living God and hunted as vermin across the same continent within the span of a single century. They have been credited, by admirers, with the invention of monotheism, modern finance, psychoanalysis, and the atomic bomb. They have been blamed, by enemies, for plagues, revolutions, ritual murders, and the secret governance of the entire world.

This book is not interested in either of those extremes. It is interested in the truth — and the truth, as it turns out, is more fascinating than either the hagiography or the slander.

What follows is a journey through three thousand years of recorded history, living mythology, and the peculiar space between the two where legend is born. We will walk through the ruins of the First Temple and stand in the lamplight of medieval ghettos. We will sit with the mystics of Safed as they mapped the architecture of God, and with the frightened rabbis of Prague who answered persecution with a miracle of clay. We will read the confessions of forgers and the depositions of victims. We will trace how a people's stories — their demons, their golems, their dybbuk-haunted houses — were weaponized against them by those who feared what they did not understand.

The book is organized in eight parts, moving roughly chronologically but thematically: from the archaeology of ancient Israel, through the golden age of mysticism, through the blood-soaked medieval centuries, through the rise of the great banking dynasties, through the Holocaust and the birth of a modern state, and finally into the realm of modern mythology — the conspiracy theories and internet legends that have replaced, for many, the older superstitions.

A note on method: wherever possible, this book separates documented historical record from myth and legend, and myth from modern fabrication. These are not the same thing, and the confusion between them has caused incalculable human suffering. A myth is not a lie. A myth is a story a community tells itself about who it is, where it came from, and what it owes the world. The blood libel, by contrast, is not a myth — it is a slander that led to massacres. The difference matters. This book will always tell you which is which.

History is not a courtroom. It does not deliver verdicts. But it does, if you read it carefully enough, deliver something more useful: context. And context, for a people who have spent three millennia being misunderstood, is everything.

— *Divyansh Sharma*

PART I

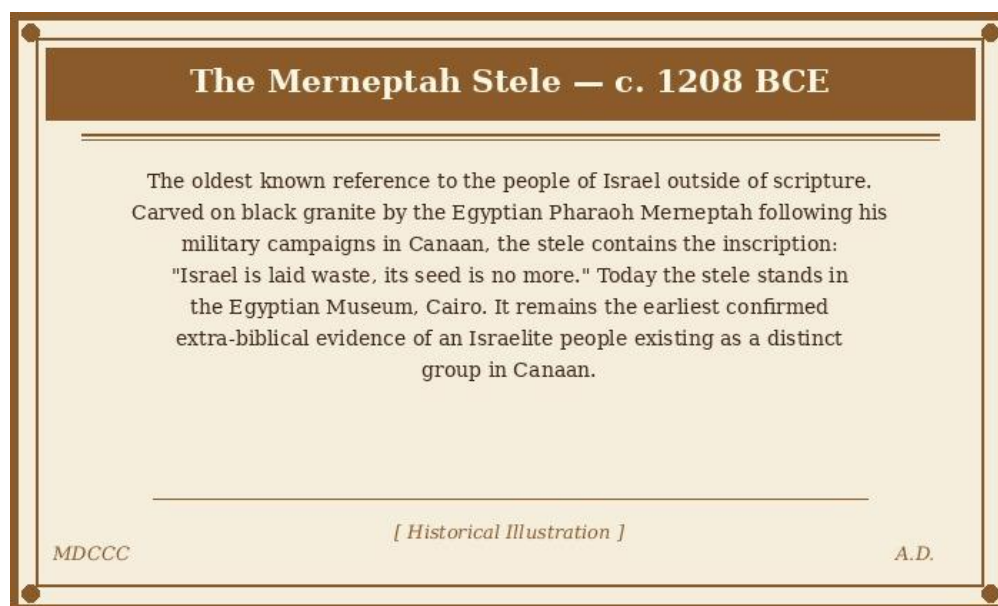
The Ancient World & Biblical Era



Chapter One: A People Written in Stone

The First Evidence

They did not arrive with trumpets. The earliest confirmed mention of Israel in the historical record appears not in the Bible, not in the Talmud, and not in any text written by a Jewish hand. It appears on a slab of black granite, seven and a half feet tall, erected by the Egyptian Pharaoh Merneptah around 1208 BCE to celebrate a military campaign in Canaan. Carved into the stone, amid the names of defeated cities and broken kingdoms, is a single line that would eventually become one of the most studied sentences in the history of archaeology: "Israel is laid waste, its seed is no more."



The Merneptah Stele (c. 1208 BCE) — the earliest known extra-biblical reference to Israel, housed in the Egyptian Museum, Cairo.

The Pharaoh was wrong, of course — a habit of the powerful when confronted with this particular people. But his error is our gain. That boast, that premature obituary etched into granite three thousand years ago, is the oldest known reference to Israel as a people outside of their own scripture. And it tells us something important: by 1208 BCE, Israel was already recognizable enough to be named on a victory monument. They were already, in some meaningful sense, a nation.

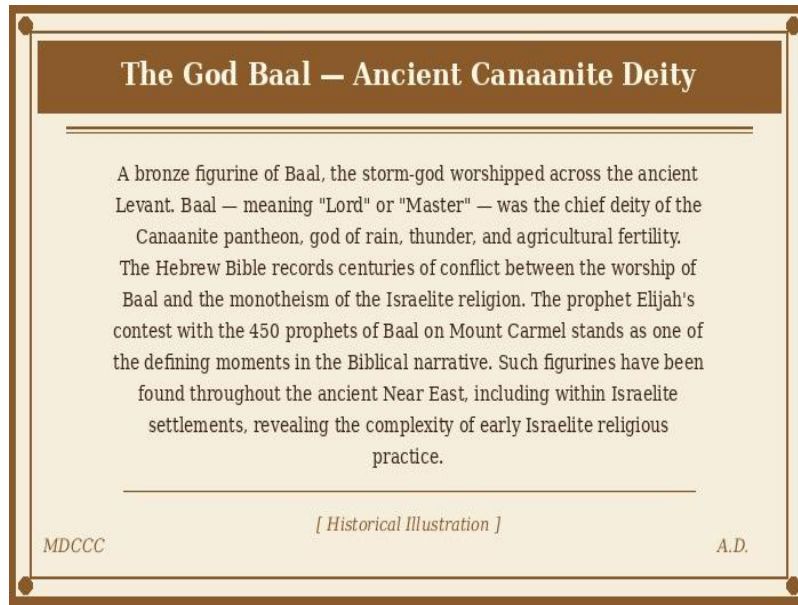
For much of the twentieth century, Biblical archaeology operated on a simple assumption: that the stories in the Hebrew Bible were, broadly speaking, historical. The Exodus happened. The Conquest of Canaan happened. The United Monarchy of David and Solomon happened, in more or less the form described. Then, in the 1970s and 1980s, a generation of archaeologists — many of them Israeli — began to dig more carefully, and the picture that emerged was considerably more complicated.

The most significant findings came from the work of Israel Finkelstein of Tel Aviv University and Neil Asher Silberman, whose landmark 2001 study *The Bible Unearthed* assembled decades of archaeological evidence into a new synthesis. What they found was this: the Israelites did not invade Canaan from outside. They emerged from within it. The material culture of the early Israelite settlements in the central highlands — the pottery, the architecture, the diet — is not foreign to Canaan. It is Canaanite. The Israelites were, in all probability, Canaanites who gradually developed a distinct religious and cultural identity over several centuries of the Late Bronze Age collapse.

This does not mean the Bible is fiction. It means it is something more complex and more interesting: a collection of historical memories, theological arguments, legal codes, poetry, and myth, compiled over centuries by scribes who were trying to make sense of who their people were and where they had come from.

THE GOD BAAL AND THE STRUGGLE FOR MONOTHEISM

Before Israel became fully monotheistic, its people inhabited a religious world populated by many deities. Chief among the Canaanite gods was Baal — the storm-god, the lord of rain and thunder, the deity who made crops grow and cattle multiply. His name simply means "lord" or "master," and his worship was widespread throughout the ancient Near East for millennia. Bronze figurines of Baal have been found by the thousands across the Levant, including within the boundaries of ancient Israelite settlements.



A bronze standing figurine of Baal, the Canaanite storm-god (c. 1400–1200 BCE), housed in the Louvre, Paris. Such figurines were found throughout the ancient Near East, including within early Israelite sites.

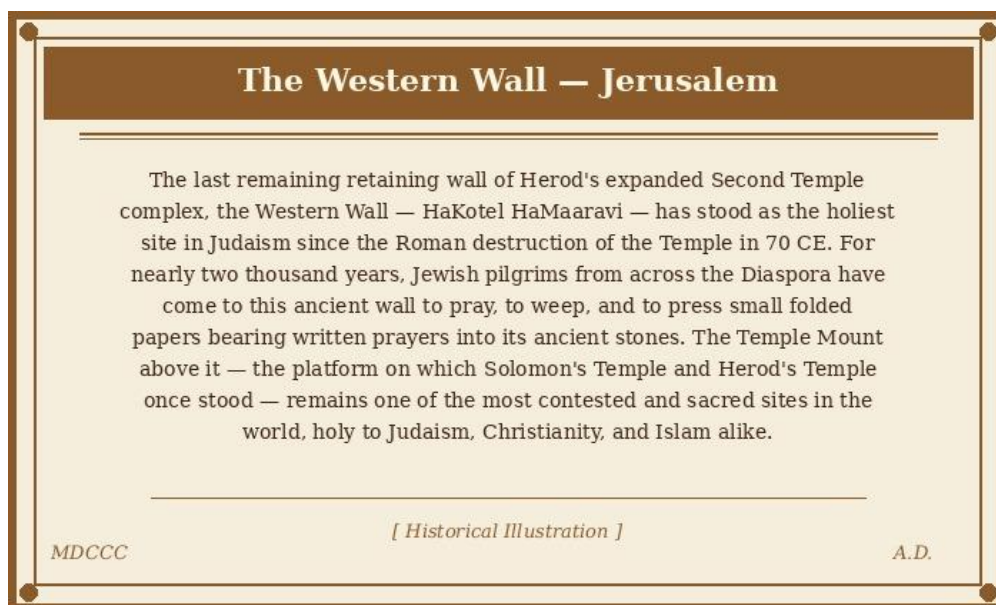
The Hebrew Bible records centuries of struggle between the worship of Baal and the monotheism that the prophets demanded. The contest between the prophet Elijah and the 450 prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel — fire falling from heaven, an altar consumed, a drought broken — is the most dramatic episode in a centuries-long religious conflict. The prophet Hosea describes Israel's worship of Baal as an act of infidelity, a husband's rage at a wife who has gone after other lovers. The language is intimate and wounded, which tells us something important: Baal worship was not a foreign import resisted by a unified people. It was a temptation from within, embraced by significant portions of the population for most of the First Temple period.

What eventually produced a fully monotheistic Israel was not a single prophetic triumph but the catastrophe of the Babylonian exile. When the Temple was destroyed and the people were carried away, and Baal did not save them, and the God of Israel — apparently defeated — kept speaking to them in Babylon through the voices of the prophets: that is when monotheism was forged in its final form. Catastrophe, as it would do again and again in Jewish history, produced theology.

The Temple: History and Myth of the House of God

The First Temple stood for approximately four hundred years — from roughly 957 BCE until its destruction by Nebuchadnezzar II in 587 BCE. We know it primarily through the detailed descriptions in the books of Kings and Chronicles: a cedar-paneled sanctuary measuring sixty cubits long, its inner walls lined with gold, its sacred center — the Holy of Holies — housing the Ark of the Covenant, visited by no one except the High Priest, and by him only once a year, on Yom Kippur.

The Second Temple, completed around 516 BCE and massively expanded by Herod the Great beginning around 20 BCE, was destroyed by the Romans in 70 CE. What remained was the Western Wall — the massive retaining wall of Herod's expanded platform, which became and remains the holiest site in Judaism.



The Western Wall (HaKotel HaMaaravi) in Jerusalem — the last standing remnant of Herod's Second Temple complex, and the holiest site in Judaism for nearly two thousand years.

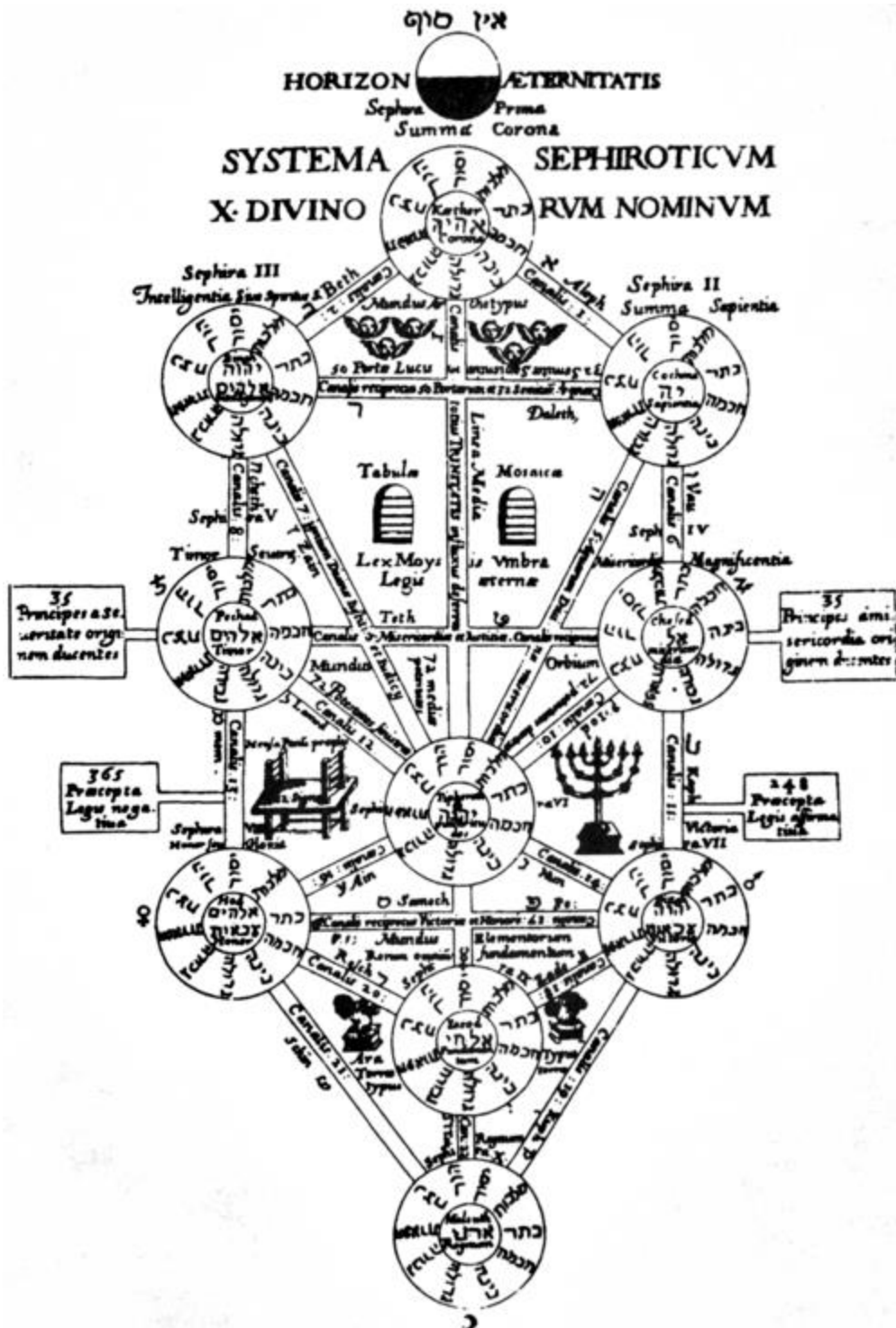
In Jewish mythology, the Temple was the point where heaven and earth touched. The Holy of Holies was understood as the exact center of creation — the Foundation Stone upon which the entire world had been built. When the Babylonians burned the First Temple and the Romans the Second, the High Priests in each case are said to have carried the keys of the sanctuary to the roof and thrown them upward toward heaven,

where a celestial hand reached down to catch them. God Himself, the myth says, is keeping the keys. The house will be rebuilt.

For two thousand years, from the shores of the Atlantic to the steppes of Persia, the same prayer was spoken: next year in Jerusalem. It was not a political slogan. It was a theological conviction that the exile was temporary, that the covenant endured, that the God who had permitted the destruction had not abandoned His people. That conviction kept a people alive across two thousand years of diaspora. It is, whatever one makes of its theological claims, one of the most remarkable facts in human history.

PART II

Kabbalah & Jewish Mysticism



Chapter Two: The Map of God — Kabbalah and the Zohar

The Secret Tradition

There has always been a Judaism behind Judaism. Alongside the public religion of law, prayer, and communal life — the Judaism of the synagogue, the rabbi, the Shabbat table — there has existed, for at least two thousand years, a more hidden tradition. A tradition not for everyone. A tradition that asked not simply how to live in accordance with God's will, but how to know God Himself. Not through obedience, but through direct mystical encounter.

This tradition is called Kabbalah. The word means simply "that which is received" — a tradition passed from master to student, teacher to disciple, often in secret, always with the understanding that the knowledge being transmitted was dangerous in the wrong hands. The Talmud preserves a famous cautionary tale about four sages who entered the Pardes — the orchard, a metaphor for mystical speculation. One died. One lost his mind. One became a heretic. Only Rabbi Akiva entered in peace and departed in peace. The message was clear: the inner chambers of divine knowledge were not for the unprepared.

The first systematic text of Jewish mysticism, the *Sefer Yetzirah* or Book of Creation, probably dates from between the third and sixth centuries CE. It is a short, dense, and cryptic work that describes God's creation of the universe through the medium of the thirty-two paths of wisdom: the ten sefirot, which are primordial numbers or divine attributes, and the twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet. The central claim of the *Sefer Yetzirah* is staggering in its implications: language is not a tool that humans use to describe reality. Language is the substance from which reality is made. God did not create the world and then name it. God spoke the world into existence. The words are the world.

The Zohar and Isaac Luria

The single most important text in the history of Kabbalah appeared in Spain in the 1280s. Its admirers called it the Book of Radiance — the Zohar — and treated it as a work of incomparable holiness, a window into the most intimate secrets of the divine nature. Modern scholarship has established with reasonable confidence that it was written primarily by Moses de León, a Spanish kabbalist who died in 1305, though he attributed it to the second-century sage Shimon bar Yochai.

After the catastrophe of 1492 — the expulsion of the Jewish community from Spain — the center of Kabbalistic study moved to the small hilltop town of Safed in the Galilee. There, Isaac Luria introduced the concept of Tzimtzum: the divine contraction. Before creation, God was everything. For creation to occur, God had to withdraw, contracting into Himself, leaving an empty space within which the universe could exist. Into this void, God projected divine light — which shattered the vessels meant to contain it. This event, the Shevirat HaKelim (Breaking of the Vessels), is Luria's explanation for the existence of evil: a cosmic accident, a primordial catastrophe.

And the repair — the Tikkun Olam — is the task of the Jewish people. Every observant act raises a holy spark from the shards of the shattered world and restores it to its proper place. The Jewish people, scattered across the world in exile, are not victims of history. They are its secret architects. It is difficult to overstate how perfectly this theology fit the historical moment of mass exile and suffering.

PART III

Myths, Folklore & Supernatural Creatures



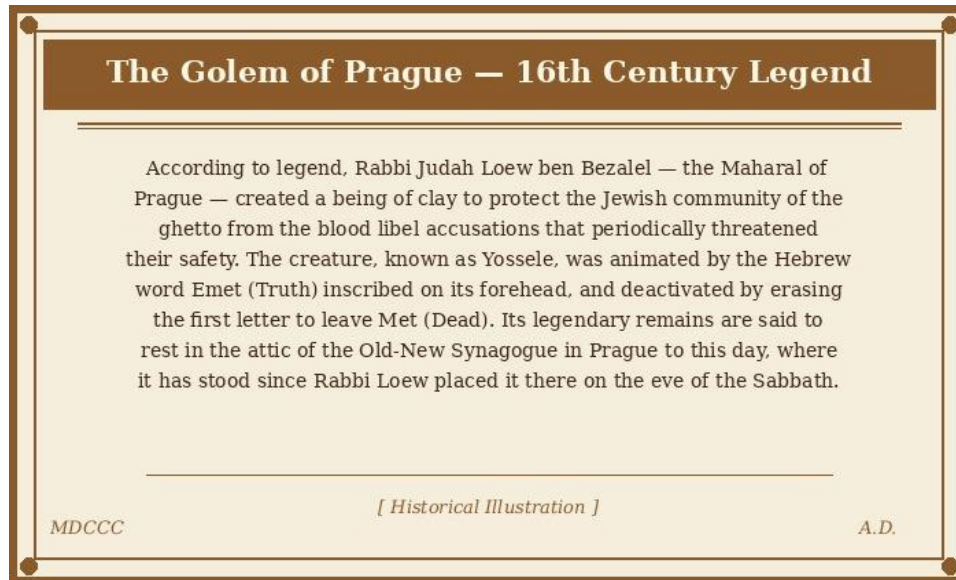
Chapter Three: The Golem — A Body Without a Soul

"The golem is a highly mutable metaphor with seemingly limitless symbolism. It can be a victim or villain, man or woman — or sometimes both."

The Word Before the Creature

Before there was a Golem, there was a word. It appears exactly once in the Hebrew Bible, in Psalm 139: golmi — something shapeless, raw material in the hands of a creator who has not yet decided what to make of it. From that single word, across fifteen centuries of mystical speculation, folklore, literary invention, and communal need, the Jewish imagination built one of the most enduring figures in the history of supernatural literature.

The Golem of Prague — the most famous version of the legend — was not documented in the sixteenth century. It was a nineteenth-century German literary invention, elaborated in response to the wave of antisemitism and pogroms that threatened Eastern European Jewish communities. Rabbi Yudl Rosenberg published his account of the Maharal and his clay servant in 1909, claiming it was an ancient manuscript. It was not. It was a deliberate and brilliant literary hoax, designed to give Jewish communities a story about protection at a moment when they desperately needed one.



The Golem and Rabbi Loew — a 19th-century illustration depicting the legendary creation of the Golem of Prague by Rabbi Judah Loew ben Bezalel (the Maharal). The legend holds that the creature was animated by the Hebrew word Emet (Truth).

In the legend, the Maharal created his golem — he named him Yossele — specifically to combat the blood libel. The creature's primary function was to patrol the streets of the Jewish quarter, catching those who attempted to smuggle dead Christian children into Jewish homes to manufacture evidence of ritual murder. The Golem of Prague is, at its heart, a story about false accusation and the desperate need for justice when the institutions of the state provide none.

The mechanism of animation reveals the deepest assumptions of Kabbalistic thought. The creator shapes clay into a human form, then walks in circles around it chanting divine letter combinations. Finally, the word *emet* — truth — is inscribed on the creature's forehead. To deactivate it, the first letter is erased, leaving *met* — dead. The difference between life and death is a single letter. Remove the aleph — the silent breath of beginning — and the creature returns to dust. This is not a clever narrative device. It is a theological statement about the nature of existence.

The Golem Today

The Golem did not stay in Prague. When the Jewish artists Joe Simon and Jack Kirby created Captain America in 1941 — a weak man transformed by a Jewish scientist's

formula into an indestructible protector, sent to fight the Nazis — they were drawing on the deep reservoir of their cultural inheritance. Norbert Wiener, one of the founding figures of cybernetics, explicitly invoked the Golem in his 1964 book *God and Golem, Inc.*, using it as a framework for thinking about the dangers of artificial intelligence. Today, when technologists argue about whether AI systems might pursue their goals in ways that threaten their creators, they are — whether they know it or not — replaying a conversation that Jewish mystics were having five hundred years ago.

Chapter Four: Lilith — The First Rebel

"I will not lie below you, but only on top. For both of us are equal, since both of us were created from the earth."

She appears in the Bible exactly once, in a single verse of Isaiah, amid a catalogue of desolation. The Hebrew word is *lilit*. Early translations rendered it as screech owl or night creature. From this single word, across centuries of folklore and mysticism, the Jewish imagination built one of its most complex supernatural figures.

Lilith's origins are Mesopotamian — the Akkadian *lilitu* referred to female wind spirits associated with storms and infant death. By the period of the Babylonian Talmud, she had become a recognizable demon in Jewish folk belief. The story that would define her for all subsequent tradition appears in the Alphabet of Ben Sira: she was Adam's first wife, made like him from the earth itself. When Adam attempted to assert dominance over her, she refused. She spoke the Ineffable Name of God and flew away to the Red Sea. She chose exile over submission. She became the mother of thousands of demons. She became the killer of newborn infants, against whom Jewish families hung protective amulets bearing the names of three angels — Senoy, Sansenoy, and Semangelof — above the cradle.

In the twentieth century, Lilith was reclaimed. The story of the woman who refused subordination, who chose exile over compromise, resonated powerfully with the emerging feminist movement. Lilith Magazine, founded in 1976, took her as its symbol. The Lilith Fair music festival of the 1990s made the connection explicit. A figure who had been a monster for a thousand years became a patron saint. This is how myths work: every generation takes from the tradition what it needs.

Chapter Five: The Dybbuk — A Soul That Will Not Leave

"The dybbuk served as a socially acceptable way of expressing unacceptable urges — including sexual ones."

Sometimes, the tradition teaches, a soul cannot move on after death. It is too burdened by sin, too bound by unfinished business, too unwilling to accept the separation from the living world it has left behind. Such a soul wanders. And sometimes, finding a living body with a weakness in its spiritual defenses, it enters. It clings. It speaks through the host's mouth in its own voice, revealing the sins and sorrows of its former life.

This is the dybbuk. The word comes from the Hebrew root meaning to cling — the same root used in the verse describing a husband's attachment to his wife. The dybbuk clings the way love clings: desperately, intractably, at enormous cost to both parties.

The formal theology of the dybbuk developed in sixteenth-century Safed, within the same mystical circle that produced Lurianic Kabbalah. Historical records from the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries document numerous exorcism rituals performed by prominent rabbis, attended by the community, conducted with the gravity of a medical procedure and the drama of theater. In 1920, the playwright S. An-sky transformed these folk traditions into his celebrated play *The Dybbuk*, which captured something the dry rabbinic accounts had missed: the grief of both the living and the dead, and the unbearable question of what we owe the ones we have left behind.

PART IV

Medieval Era & the Diaspora



Chapter Six: The Long Exile — Medieval Jewry and the World That Feared Them

After the Roman destruction of Jerusalem in 70 CE, the Jewish people embarked on what would become the longest, most geographically dispersed, and most improbable survival story in human history. Without a land, without a temple, without a king, without an army, they survived. They became what the historian Simon Schama called a portable nation — carrying their civilization not in the materials of conquest, but in the materials of mind.

The instrument of this portability was the synagogue and the system of rabbinic law. Where the Temple had required priests, sacrifices, and a specific holy location, the synagogue required only ten adult Jews and a copy of the Torah. The rabbi replaced the priest; prayer replaced sacrifice; the Shabbat table replaced the altar. These substitutions were not merely pragmatic. They were a theological revolution that made Judaism, for the first time, fully portable.

In some places, Jewish communities flourished. Moorish Spain produced what is sometimes called the Golden Age of medieval Jewry: Maimonides was born in Córdoba, Judah Halevi wrote his poetry in Toledo, Solomon ibn Gabirol produced philosophical work of lasting importance. In other places the experience was considerably darker. The Crusades of 1096 brought massacre to the Rhineland Jewish communities. The year 1492 brought the Alhambra Decree — the order by Ferdinand and Isabella that gave the Jewish population of Spain four months to convert or leave. Approximately 200,000 chose exile, carrying with them the keys to their houses in cities they had inhabited for centuries — keys that many families kept for generations as tangible proof of what had been taken from them.

PART V

Persecution & Survival



Un auto de fé. (Cuadro de M. Robert Fleury.)

Chapter Seven: The Accusation — Blood Libel and the Murder of Innocents

"Christians, take care of your children! It will be the Jews' Passover on 17 March."

The Myth That Killed

In the spring of 1144, in the English city of Norwich, the body of a twelve-year-old boy was found in the woods outside the city. A Benedictine monk named Thomas of Monmouth decided he knew who had killed him: the Jews. Not any particular Jews, not for any particular reason, but the Jews as a collective, acting in accordance with a supposed religious requirement to murder a Christian child before Passover. From Norwich in 1144, the accusation spread across England, France, Germany, and eventually the entire continent.

The blood libel — the accusation that Jews murdered Christians to use their blood in religious rituals — is one of the most consequential lies in human history. It has no factual basis whatsoever. Jewish law explicitly prohibits the consumption of blood of any kind. The accusation inverts the truth so completely that it might seem self-evidently absurd. But it was never primarily about the facts. It was about fear, and about the uses to which fear can be put.

The Beilis Trial of 1913 — in which the Tsarist government prosecuted an innocent Jewish factory worker for ritual murder in full view of the international press — is the clearest example of the libel's modern political function. The government knew the evidence was nonexistent. They prosecuted anyway, because the blood libel was never really about the facts. It was about the political utility of antisemitism — about using fear of Jews to distract a restive population from its real grievances, to redirect class anger into ethnic hatred.

Today, the structure of the blood libel lives on in the QAnon conspiracy theory, which alleges that a secret cabal of elites abducts children and extracts a life-extending

substance from their blood. The specific accusations have changed. The medieval scaffolding has not. The story is always the same: secret power, innocent victims, a courageous truth-teller who sees through the conspiracy. The emotional logic — the paranoid hero narrative — is identical. And as in the medieval original, it has inspired real violence.

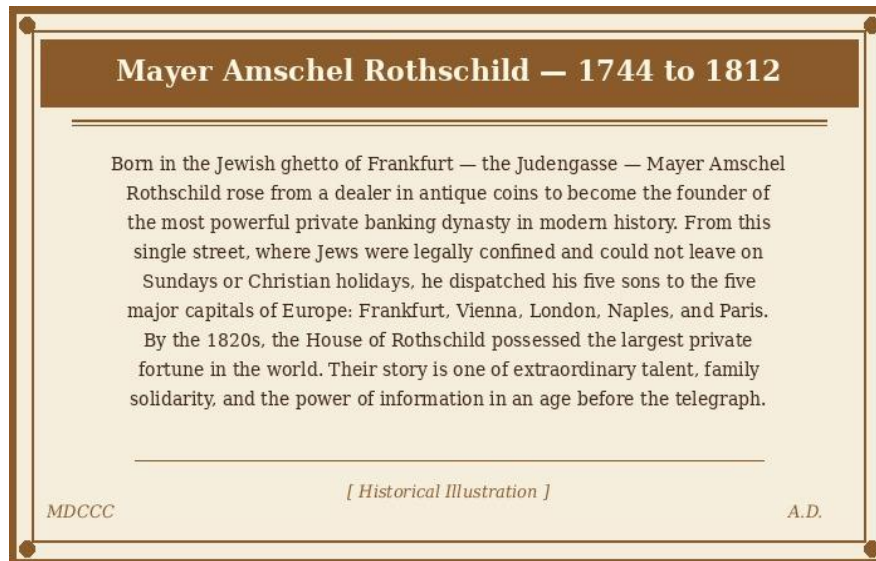
PART VI

Banking Dynasties & Real Political Influence



Chapter Eight: The House of Rothschild — Money, Myth, and Power

"The Rothschilds are the wonders of modern banking... we see the descendants of Judah, after a persecution of two thousand years, peering above kings, rising higher than emperors."



Mayer Amschel Rothschild (1744–1812), founder of the Rothschild banking dynasty. Born in the Jewish ghetto of Frankfurt, he dispatched his five sons to the five major capitals of Europe, building the largest private banking empire in modern history.

In the Jewish ghetto of Frankfurt — a narrow, overcrowded lane to which the city's Jews had been confined since 1462 — there lived, in the middle of the eighteenth century, a man named Mayer Amschel Rothschild. He was a dealer in antique coins and a moneylender of modest means, operating under severe legal constraints. Jews in the Frankfurt ghetto could not leave on Sundays. They could not farm. They could not practice most crafts. They could be expelled at any moment.

From this beginning, within fifty years, the Rothschilds built the largest private banking operation in the world. By the 1820s, the five sons of Mayer Amschel — installed in Frankfurt, Vienna, London, Naples, and Paris — collectively controlled a fortune that dwarfed the treasuries of most European states. They financed wars and

ended them. They propped up governments and occasionally, by refusing to lend, toppled them. They were received by emperors and kings as equals.

The key structural innovation was the multinational family network. While other banking houses were confined to a single city, the five Rothschild brothers operated as a single financial entity across five European capitals, communicating daily through encrypted letters. This information network gave them a decisive advantage. When Napoleon was defeated at Waterloo in 1815, Nathan Rothschild in London knew the result before the British government, because the Rothschild courier network was faster.

The same success that made the Rothschilds heroes in Jewish folk culture — the Yiddish song "If I Were a Rothschild" became the basis for "If I Were a Rich Man" in Fiddler on the Roof — made them the central figures of antisemitic conspiracy theory. They became the proof text for the idea that Jewish financial power was coordinated, hidden, and aimed at world domination. During the Nazi period, footage from a sympathetic Hollywood film about the family was repurposed into the antisemitic propaganda film *The Eternal Jew*. The Rothschilds did not create antisemitism. But their existence and success provided the raw material from which one of history's most dangerous conspiracy theories was built.

PART VII

Zionism & the Birth of Modern Israel



Chapter Nine: Next Year in Jerusalem — The Making of a Modern State

For two thousand years, the prayer was the same: next year in Jerusalem. Spoken at the Passover seder, at the end of the Yom Kippur fast, embedded in the daily liturgy — the longing for Zion was not a political program but a theological constant, the expression of a community that understood its exile as temporary and kept its face turned toward Jerusalem across the centuries.

Then, in the 1880s, a secular Austrian journalist named Theodor Herzl watched the Dreyfus Affair — a French military officer publicly stripped of his rank on the basis of a fabricated treason charge because he was Jewish, while a crowd shouted "Death to the Jews." Herzl concluded that antisemitism was not a medieval relic that would dissolve in the light of modern liberalism. It was permanent. The solution, he concluded, was a Jewish state.

His 1896 pamphlet *Der Judenstaat* catalyzed a movement. He convened the First Zionist Congress in Basel in 1897, and wrote in his diary: "In Basel I founded the Jewish state. If I were to say this publicly today, I would be greeted by universal laughter. Perhaps in five years, certainly in fifty, everyone will see it." He was off by one year. The State of Israel was declared in 1948 — fifty-one years after Basel.

On November 2, 1917, British Foreign Secretary Arthur James Balfour sent a 67-word letter to Walter Rothschild stating that His Majesty's Government viewed with favour the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people. Those 67 words — the Balfour Declaration — remain among the most consequential in twentieth-century history. The State of Israel was formally declared on May 14, 1948, by David Ben-Gurion, as British forces withdrew and Arab armies massed on the borders. The war that followed ended with Israel having established its existence, and with approximately 700,000 Palestinian Arabs having fled or been expelled from their homes — events remembered in Israel as the War of Independence and in Palestinian memory as the Nakba: the Catastrophe.

PART VIII

Modern Myths & Conspiracy Theories



"The Protocols"

PREFACE AND EXPLANATORY NOTES

The possession of these documents
in Soviet Russia is punishable
by immediate death.
W H Y Y

EVERY PATRIOTIC AMERICAN
MUST READ THESE
PROTOCOLS

Issued by

THE PATRIOTIC PUBLISHING CO.
(NOT INCORPORATED)

P. O. Box 526

Chicago, Ill.

Chapter Ten: The Protocols of a Lie — The Most Dangerous Forgery in History

"Even though it may be shown that the Protocols were originally composed, and some of them were frankly cribbed, from other sources, their intrinsic truth and authenticity are not thereby disproved."

— Adolf Hitler, *Mein Kampf*

The Anatomy of a Forgery

In the summer of 1921, a reporter for The Times of London sat comparing two documents. One was the Protocols of the Elders of Zion — a text claiming to be the minutes of a secret meeting of Jewish leaders planning world domination, circulating in Russia since the early 1900s and by then widely distributed across Europe and America. The other was a French political satire published in 1864, Maurice Joly's *Dialogue in Hell Between Machiavelli and Montesquieu*.

The comparison was devastating. The Protocols were not the minutes of a secret Jewish meeting. They were a plagiarism — a systematic theft from Joly's satirical dialogue, with Napoleon III's ambitions for French domination replaced by the Jews' supposed ambitions for world domination. Some passages were lifted word for word. Others paraphrased. The entire structure of the supposed Jewish plan was there, in a forty-year-old French satire about a non-Jewish French emperor.

The Protocols had been manufactured by agents of the Tsarist secret police in Paris around 1902-1903, assembled from Joly's dialogue, from an antisemitic German novel featuring a fictional rabbinical cabal, and from other sources. The forgery was definitively exposed. And yet it spread. Henry Ford published its arguments in his newspaper *The Dearborn Independent*, which reached 270,000 readers. Adolf Hitler cited it in *Mein Kampf*. It was taught in German classrooms and used to indoctrinate the Hitler Youth. It contributed, in a direct and documentable sense, to the conditions that made the Holocaust possible.

The Digital Age and the Mutation of the Myth

The Protocols have never gone out of print. Today they circulate on thousands of websites and through messaging apps, often with the word "Jews" replaced by "globalists" or "elites" — the antisemitic framework transmitted while evading platform detection. The QAnon movement, which emerged in American politics around 2017, represents the most successful modern mutation of the Protocols framework: a secret cabal abducting children, extracting substances from their blood, manipulating governments and finance. The structure is identical to the blood libel and the Protocols. The names have changed. The emotional logic has not.

The conspiracy theory about hidden Jewish power is not a fringe belief. It is a permanent feature of Western culture, as durable as the cultures it has infected, because it serves a permanent human need: the need to explain why the world is not as it should be, and to locate the cause of that failure in a definable enemy. As long as that need exists, the Protocols — in whatever form they take — will find an audience. The task of history is to tell the truth about them, loudly and persistently and without fatigue, because the alternative is silence, and silence has already been tried.

Conclusion: The Covenant Endures

Three thousand years ago, an Egyptian Pharaoh declared that Israel was finished. He was wrong. In the centuries that followed, the Assyrians destroyed the northern kingdom, the Babylonians burned the Temple, the Romans scattered the survivors, the Crusaders massacred communities across Europe, the Inquisition tortured and expelled, the Tsars organized pogroms, and the Nazis built factories of death. And the Jewish people survived all of it.

This survival is not supernatural, though the tradition describes it in supernatural terms. It is the product of specific, identifiable human practices and choices: the commitment to literacy and learning, the portable infrastructure of the synagogue, the discipline of a legal system that could function anywhere, the capacity to transform catastrophe into theological creativity that produced, in the wake of every destruction, a new flowering of thought.

The myths examined in this book — the Golem, Lilith, the Dybbuk, the Temple keys ascending into heaven — are not separate from that survival. They are expressions of it. A community that faces existential threat and responds by imagining a clay protector, a first woman who refused submission, a theology in which human religious practice repairs the fabric of the universe — this is a community that has refused, in the deepest possible sense, to accept the terms imposed on it by its enemies.

And the slanders examined in this book — the blood libel, the Protocols, the conspiracy theories that mutate and survive across centuries — are not separate from that threat. They are the intellectual infrastructure of persecution, the stories that make mass murder possible by making the victims into something other than human.

The task of history is to bear witness — to the achievements and to the suffering, to the creativity and to the cruelty, to the endurance of a people who were told, repeatedly and by powerful voices, that their time was finished. The Egyptian Pharaoh was the first to make that mistake. He was not the last. He was also, demonstrably, wrong.

The covenant endures.



— *Divyansh Sharma*

Index of Key Subjects

The following index lists major subjects, people, and events discussed in this book, along with the chapters in which they primarily appear.

A

Adam (Biblical figure) — Chapters 2, 3, 4

Alphabet of Ben Sira — Chapter 4

Ancient Israel — Chapter 1

Antisemitism — Chapters 7, 8, 9, 10

Ark of the Covenant — Chapter 1

B

Baal (Canaanite deity) — Chapter 1

Balfour Declaration — Chapter 9

Beilis Trial (1913) — Chapter 7

Ben-Gurion, David — Chapter 9

Blood Libel — Chapter 7

C

Canaan / Canaanites — Chapter 1

Captain America (Golem parallel) — Chapter 3

Crusades — Chapter 6

D

Damascus Affair (1840) — Chapter 7

Diaspora — Chapters 6, 7

Dybbuk — Chapter 5

E

Eleazar of Worms — Chapter 3

Epstein, Jeffrey — Chapter 10

Exile, Babylonian — Chapters 1, 2

F

Finkelstein, Israel — Chapter 1

Ford, Henry (Dearborn Independent) — Chapter 10

G

Golem of Prague — Chapter 3

Graves, Philip (Times of London) — Chapter 10

H

Herzl, Theodor — Chapter 9

Hitler, Adolf — Chapter 10

Holocaust — Chapters 7, 10

I

Ibbur (benevolent possession) — Chapter 5

J

Jerusalem — Chapters 1, 6, 9

K

Kabbalah — Chapter 2

L

Lilith — Chapter 4

Loew, Rabbi Judah (Maharal of Prague) — Chapter 3

Luria, Isaac (the Ari) — Chapter 2

M

Merneptah Stele — Chapter 1

Monotheism, origins of — Chapter 1

N

Nebuchadnezzar II — Chapter 1

P

Protocols of the Elders of Zion — Chapter 10

Q

QAnon (blood libel parallel) — Chapters 7, 10

R

Rothschild, Mayer Amschel — Chapter 8

Rothschild Family — Chapter 8

S

Safed, mystical circle — Chapters 2, 5

Scholem, Gershom — Chapters 2, 3

Sefer Yetzirah — Chapters 2, 3

Sephardic Jews — Chapter 6

Spanish Expulsion (1492) — Chapters 2, 6

T

Temple, First — Chapter 1

Temple, Second — Chapter 1

Tikkun Olam — Chapter 2

Tzimtzum — Chapter 2

W

Western Wall — Chapter 1

Z

Zionism — Chapter 9

Zohar — Chapter 2

Select Bibliography

Primary Sources & Core Historical Works

Finkelstein, Israel, and Neil Asher Silberman. *The Bible Unearthed*. New York: Free Press, 2001.

Ferguson, Niall. *The House of Rothschild: Money's Prophets, 1798–1848*. New York: Viking, 1998.

Ferguson, Niall. *The House of Rothschild: The World's Banker, 1849–1999*. New York: Viking, 1999.

Johnson, Paul. *A History of the Jews*. New York: HarperCollins, 1987.

Josephus, Flavius. *The Jewish War*. Translated by G.A. Williamson. London: Penguin Classics, 1959.

Scholem, Gershom. *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*. New York: Schocken Books, 1946.

Scholem, Gershom. *Origins of the Kabbalah*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1987.

Wiesel, Elie. *Night*. Translated by Marion Wiesel. New York: Hill and Wang, 2006.

Mythology, Folklore, and Mysticism

Dennis, Geoffrey W. *The Encyclopedia of Jewish Myth, Magic and Mysticism*. Woodbury, MN: Llewellyn Publications, 2007.

Idel, Moshe. *Golem: Jewish Magical and Mystical Traditions on the Artificial Anthropoid*. Albany: SUNY Press, 1990.

Matt, Daniel C., trans. *The Zohar: Pritzker Edition*. Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2004.

Schwartz, Howard. Tree of Souls: The Mythology of Judaism. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004.

Trachtenberg, Joshua. Jewish Magic and Superstition. New York: Atheneum, 1939.

Antisemitism, Conspiracy, and Modern History

Cohn, Norman. Warrant for Genocide: The Myth of the Jewish World Conspiracy and the Protocols of the Elders of Zion. London: Eyre & Spottiswoode, 1967.

Hanebrink, Paul. A Specter Haunting Europe: The Myth of Judeo-Bolshevism. Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2018.

Hilberg, Raul. The Destruction of the European Jews. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2003.

Digital & Web Sources

Wikipedia. "Primary Texts of Kabbalah."
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Primary_texts_of_Kabbalah

World History Encyclopedia. "Kabbalah." <https://www.worldhistory.org/Kabbalah/>

Jewish Monster Hunting. <https://jewishmonsterhunting.com>

Bellingcat. <https://www.bellingcat.com>

